

Chapter 81 - Appearing

Wild geese came and swallows returned¹. This year's autumn days were all bright and sunny, except for the day of White Dew² when a gentle, persistent rain began to fall. The rain was soft and long-lasting, making the disciples of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate lose their motivation to cultivate. They all crowded into Pearl Light Pavilion and Treasure Energy Studio, staring blankly at the moist jade steps under the eaves.

"Another winter is coming," sighed a female disciple with sky-high braids, lying on the table. "When will these days full of demon troubles end? Endlessly going down the mountain to eliminate demons - I've done so much my eyes are blurred."

"Come on, Tao Tao³, with your level of cultivation you can only cut off little demons' tails. The ones who are really tired are the fellow disciples from East and West Courts. I heard Senior Brother Hong Ying was injured again a few days ago. He still has an arm that can't be reattached and is lying in the Medical Immortal's care," another female disciple from North Court sighed along with her. "Now it's this rotten autumn with dark clouds everywhere - so annoying it could kill you."

"The current situation is really bad. My father deals in immortal escorts⁴, and he says many places in the mortal realm are in dire straits. Demons are causing chaos everywhere, even destroying many crop fields. It's really too much," the female disciple tapped the window frame.

"Moreover, I heard that even the Divine Venerable is severely injured and hasn't recovered." She secretly pulled Tao Tao's ear closer. "A few days ago, I was ordered to deliver something to the Divine Venerable. I secretly saw the Divine Venerable coughing up blood in front of several Medical Immortals. It really looks like serious injuries. What if our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate again..."

Before she could finish, several coughs came from behind them. Turning around, they saw Liu Wenzhu with her hair tied up and a serious expression, followed by Feng Ge who had just returned from outside, drenched.

"Not cultivating in broad daylight but gossiping about the sect leader here - do you all want to be punished?" Feng Ge waved her hand, splashing water all over them. The two quickly covered their mouths and fled with their heads down.

"These people really don't let one worry," Feng Ge shook her head and cast a spell to dry the moisture from her body.

Liu Wenzhu shook her head: "Can't really blame them. The current situation is indeed unclear, so worry is inevitable."

As she spoke, she looked up through the window frame at the dark, low-hanging clouds outside: "This weather has changed too quickly."

She wasn't the only one watching the sky overhead.

Behind the mountain on a cliff, a figure like smoke drifted ghostlike under a tree. Hanging tree leaves obscured his face, and the gentle rain fell like cow's hair, but slid aside the moment it touched him.

So although he stood in the rain, the ground beneath his feet was dry.

Another wisp of black smoke emerged beside him, vaguely human-shaped, speaking respectfully: "Your Highness, are you really going to strike tonight? We don't have enough people - most are blocked outside the mountain by barriers, so the formation isn't fully set up yet. Acting now carries unpredictable risks."

The figure gave a light scoff: "I nearly destroyed the Emei Thorns⁵, only managing to break a few strings of the Eastern Wilderness Kong Hou⁶, luring those damned dog immortal sects to the Eastern Wilderness. Plus that foolish woman was severely injured by me last time. How could there be such a good opportunity again in the future?"

"Moreover, I've inquired about the Eastern Wilderness - that Kong Hou is almost fully repaired. If we still hesitate now, we'll miss our chance."

"I've waited for years. I can't endure another day of hiding my identity and living wretchedly! Once I complete his instructions, I can return to his side!" the man declared forcefully.

After his voice shook the tree branches, causing water to patter down, he calmed himself and smiled again.

"So I will strike tonight. Whatever the formation can accomplish is what it is. When have I ever feared a mere Chu Qingqiu? The high and mighty Divine Venerable Chu Ling - tonight I want to see her trampled under my feet like a puddle of mud, see her kneel and beg me for mercy!"

His lips revealed a sinister smile: "The blood feud of the past - I'll make her pay the price."

"As for that waste Ning Fuyi, so what if she has a divine sword? Once Chu Qingqiu dies and no one protects her anymore, won't she just be a dog that can be easily kicked to death!"

"Yes, Your Highness," the dark shadow bowed, then the shadow disappeared, leaving only rolling black smoke and rain threads filling the sky.

This rain didn't last all night. It stopped when night fell deep, but the dark clouds in the sky still didn't disperse, instead becoming even more oppressively low.

Tranquil Mountain Palace was as quiet as usual. The immortal attendants had gone to bed early, fallen leaves in the courtyard hadn't been swept, and were stuck to the smooth jade stone paths after being soaked by rain, covering the palace buildings with a layer of desolation.

The flowers that had been blooming vibrantly just days ago had also withered, leaving only a few bare stems swaying in the wind.

No one noticed that the originally clear night was slowly being shrouded by a thin layer of smoke, spreading from mid-air, isolating the entire Tranquil Mountain Palace and blocking the demonic energy that was dissolving the palace's original barriers.

A man in black robes appeared in the dim light, his figure flashing as he stood atop the pavilion.

Qiuyi, who was guarding the door, immediately awakened in alarm, quickly drawing her curved blade, but was struck by the man's palm and sent flying out of the railing, splashing into the pond water.

"Overestimating fool," the man smiled with curved lips. "You all, go kill everyone in this palace. Don't let a single one escape."

As soon as he finished speaking, the surrounding shadows all stood up one by one, transforming into real people, all responding in unison before leaving separately.

He pushed the door and entered the room. Inside was pitch black with no lights, filled with faint medicinal and bloody scents.

He could see clearly in the darkness without needing to light a lamp, turning around the screen barrier and walking toward the inner room.

As soon as his body entered the doorway, a strong immortal wind blew from his side. The man seemed to have anticipated this, his folding fan spinning to block the attack, then his long sleeves turned in a circle, and a palm crackling with lightning immediately struck the woman in the shadows. A muffled groan was heard as the woman crashed hard into the wall.

The man laughed heartily, raising his hand to light the fire, leaning down to look at the thin figure that had slid down and was half-kneeling on the ground.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, good evening," he said eerily.

Chu Qingqiu tightly covered her heart, blood threads flowing from the corners of her lips, looking up at the man in shock, using her white sleeves to wipe away the blood.

"Elder Yuan Ming⁷, it really is you."

"You actually already guessed who I am? You still have some intelligence." The man clapped his hands methodically. The mask fell from his face, revealing a familiar, refined countenance, though that face now carried more gloom and less of the feigned carefree and unrestrained air.

"I really don't know when I exposed my identity?"

Chu Qingqiu breathed slowly, her voice weak but clear: "Only you were present on the Flying Eagle Boat. You were nowhere to be found whenever demon clan appeared. And there were the vines you used when bewitching Li Chao'an⁸... You left quite a few traces. But to actually strike within Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate - what audacity!"

The man burst into hearty laughter again: "Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate? You foolish woman, do you think I'd fear a few broken elders? I'll kill you first, then wipe out the entire sect later - wouldn't that be more interesting?"

As he spoke, he summoned the Emei Thorns with a reverse hand gesture. The sky, which had stopped its wind and rain, suddenly thundered, then lightning split the night sky with explosive sounds that shook heaven and earth, completely splitting open the roof above.

Countless debris and stones fell with the night wind. Chu Qingqiu waved her sleeve to block them, but black smoke from the man's palm had already wrapped around her neck, forcefully pressing her against the broken walls: "Chu Qingqiu, you have this day too! You also have times when you're afraid?"

"If you're afraid, beg me for mercy, and perhaps I can leave you with an intact corpse."

His eyes under the mask revealed fierce light, satisfied as he watched the helpless expression in the woman's eyes and her gradually paling, blood-stained face.

"Tsk tsk tsk, such a beautiful face - how did it end up on a woman like you?" The man feigned pity, his corpse-like voice ugly and hoarse, not seeing the cold light that flashed momentarily in the woman's eyes. "Don't worry, after you die, I'll go kill that little waste and let her accompany you in death."

As he spoke, he reached toward her face, but just as he was about to touch it, the weak woman who had been coughing blood suddenly shouted "White Bone!" A white jade staff suddenly appeared in her palm, whipping up a fierce wind that severed the black energy in his grasp.

The man immediately stepped back two paces, looking at Chu Qingqiu who still dared to fight back. Killing intent surged through his brow as he roared, and the Emei Thorns in his hand suddenly emitted blue light, transforming into countless sharp blades surging toward the woman.

However, the moment the blades touched the woman, her body burst with blinding golden light, not only blocking those blades but also radiating outward from within like a violent storm. Though the wind was invisible, it was like bronze and iron. The man couldn't block it in time and felt his waist nearly severed by this wind, his body flying far before barely stabilizing.

"Tianshan's Golden Thread Garment⁹? Chu Qingqiu, even at death's door you still don't forget to cling to life. In that case, I'll make you watch this Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate be destroyed, watch that little waste die miserably!" The man glared with widened eyes and roared.

Before his words ended, his body soared into the air, spreading his arms and howling at the sky. His cry filled heaven and earth, followed by an eerie calm, quiet as death itself.

And just when it seemed nothing had happened, the ground of Tranquil Mountain Palace, the distant bamboo forest behind the mountain, and the steep cliffs all began to stir with dark shadows, as if something was rustling up from the earth.

"Vengeful spirits?" Chu Qingqiu frowned in shock, her hair scattered in the wind.

"Exactly!" The man laughed triumphantly without restraint. "Have you heard of the demon clan's Ten Thousand Ghosts Coming to Court¹⁰? Today I'll definitely turn your Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate into a sea of ghosts!"

He spoke with complete confidence as he waved his hand to activate the formation, but his smile abruptly stopped, replaced by astonishment: "What's happening? My Bone Enchantress..."

He suddenly realized, glaring at Chu Qingqiu: "It's you, you..."

When his gaze moved over, the woman who had been pale just moments before suddenly looked up, the shock and helplessness in her eyes instantly replaced by the coldness of looking at a dead person.

The moment he met those peach blossom eyes, goosebumps instantly covered the man's hands. He turned to look around, only to see that the previously empty, dark rooftops in the distance now had four people standing on them.

"Your formation can't be used anymore, Elder Yuan Ming," the woman's tone had no fluctuation, but hearing it was like the depths of winter.

"Then, it's this venerable's turn."

Ning Fuyi suddenly shot up from bed, breathing heavily, cold sweat sliding down with her movement and dripping into her eyes, making them sting.

She closed her eyes to wipe away the sweat, looking out the window in bewilderment.

Outside, dark clouds gathered, but it was quiet and peaceful, with only wind passing through the treetops, shaking down raindrops remaining from the day.

Two birds, one black and one white, nestled together on the windowsill sheltering from rain, now also entering dreamland.

No matter how you looked at it, it was just an ordinary night, yet she had suddenly awakened from her dream just now, her heart beating like turbulent seas.

Could something have happened to Chu Qingqiu? Otherwise, why would she be so nervous? She hadn't wanted to go out for several days now. Although she indeed didn't want to see Chu Qingqiu right now, although anger and disappointment still filled her heart, but...

But she should still go take a look, even if just from outside the courtyard.

Thinking this, she turned over and got out of bed, nearly kicking the small azure-yellow qilin sleeping at the foot of the bed. The little qilin immediately transformed into human form, yawning with an annoyed expression.

"Ning Fuyi, what are you doing not sleeping in the middle of the night, disturbing people's peace," Jiuying covered her red lips and reproached.

"I feel uncomfortable inside, want to go out and look," Ning Fuyi ignored her and continued toward the door, but her hand suddenly stopped when it touched the door, her dark brows furrowing.

"Someone's coming," Ning Fuyi stepped back against the wall. Lovesickness instantly appeared in her palm, concealing its dim pink light.

"Very strong immortal energy, not demonic," Jiuying also got up from bed, speaking quietly in her mind. "The visitor has extremely high cultivation - I've never sensed anything like it in Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. But there's no demonic energy, so they should not be bad people."

Ning Fuyi turned her head toward the direction outside the door, quietly shaking her head: "No, Jiuying, quickly come in!"

"Don't worry about your divine beast dignity, hurry!" She raised her arm toward Jiuying. Jiuying silently stamped her feet on the spot, then transformed into points of light, falling into a prayer bead¹¹.

At the same time, the door was knocked on with heavy thuds.

"Left Envoy of Penglai¹², Wen Yaojun¹³, by order of Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord¹⁴, here to interrogate the daughter of former sect leader Ning Changfeng¹⁵, Ning Fuyi."

Footnotes:

¹ **Wild geese came and swallows returned (鸿雁来，玄鸟归)** - A poetic expression referring to the changing of seasons, specifically autumn arrivals and departures of migratory birds

² **White Dew (白露)** - One of the 24 solar terms in the traditional Chinese calendar, occurring around September 7-9, marking the beginning of cool autumn weather

³ **Tao Tao (陶桃)** - A name combining the surname Tao with "peach," suggesting a sweet or innocent character

⁴ **Immortal escorts (仙镖)** - Courier services that transport goods for cultivators and immortals, similar to martial escort agencies in wuxia

⁵ **Emei Thorns (峨眉刺)** - Ning Fuyi's signature weapon, thin needle-like weapons

⁶ **Kong Hou (箜篌)** - An ancient Chinese harp-like stringed instrument

⁷ **Yuan Ming (元明)** - The elder who has been revealed as the traitor/demon clan member

⁸ **Li Chao'an (李朝安)** - A character mentioned earlier in the story

⁹ **Tianshan's Golden Thread Garment (天山的金缕衣)** - A legendary protective garment, likely providing magical defense

¹⁰ **Ten Thousand Ghosts Coming to Court (万鬼来朝)** - A powerful demonic formation that summons numerous vengeful spirits

¹¹ **Prayer bead (念珠)** - Buddhist prayer beads, here used as a storage/hiding place for Jiuying

¹² **Penglai (蓬莱)** - The immortal realm, one of the major powers in this story

¹³ **Wen Yaojun (文曜君)** - An official title in Penglai's hierarchy

¹⁴ **Heavenly Auspicious Imperial Lord (天瑞帝君)** - The ruler of Penglai

¹⁵ **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's mother, the previous sect leader